

Nicole Simmons, M.Ed.

Performance & Systems Leader · Learning Design · AI Integration

K–12 Instructional Leadership · Curriculum & Coaching · Research & Design

“Using what is known to do better.”

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A practitioner who builds the systems she leads.

Nicole Simmons is a K–12 instructional leader and learning designer with 15+ years of experience across California and South Carolina — classroom teacher, instructional coach, TOSA, curriculum designer, and founding-team site administrator. Her work pairs measurable performance results with the systems thinking and learning design depth that EdTech, L&D, and consulting environments need.

Outside of full-time roles, she maintains an independent research and design portfolio under the ForwardEd name (ForwardEd.consulting) — a self-directed initiative used to keep skills sharp, prototype AI-enabled tools, publish original research, and showcase design work. The portfolio includes three self-published white papers, a self-built diagnostic prototype (Cohesion Baseline), and a research-cited MTSS framework. It exists to demonstrate capability — not to compete with a prospective employer's time or focus.

What I do

- **Diagnose** structural issues in K–12 systems using research-grounded analysis (not anecdote, not optics).
- **Design** frameworks, tools, and learning experiences that align curriculum, instruction, and support around measurable outcomes.
- **Build** shipped artifacts — white papers, diagnostic tools, web platforms, professional learning — not just slide decks.
- **Coach** leaders and teams through the work, with the professional courage to stay in the room when the answer is uncomfortable.

Independent Portfolio Work

Self-directed research, design, and prototyping — built outside of professional employment to demonstrate capability and explore ideas. Most candidates describe what they led. This section shows what was built.

PERSONAL PORTFOLIO INITIATIVE

ForwardEd

Independent research and design portfolio · ForwardEd.consulting

A self-directed, AI-collaborative initiative used to research, prototype, and publish work in K–12 systems thinking and learning design. Designed the brand identity, content strategy, and web platform end-to-end, and produced the full content catalog under personal authorship.

The initiative is governed by four operating principles:

- **Evidence over optics** — let the data show what is and isn't working before drawing conclusions.
- **Systems before symptoms** — diagnose structures and processes before assigning blame to individuals.
- **Design to reduce burden** — educator and learner load is usually a system-design problem, not an effort problem.
- **Transparent practice** — every framework, finding, and AI-assisted analysis disclosed openly.

SELF-BUILT PROTOTYPE · AI-ENABLED DIAGNOSTIC

Cohesion Baseline

Diagnostic prototype for K–12 system coherence · ForwardEd.consulting/cohesion-baseline

A self-built, password-protected diagnostic prototype in early calibration. Designed to surface where curriculum, instruction, and support are — and are not — working coherently as a system. AI provides the analytical lens; the framework provides the structure; the leader supplies judgment about what to act on.

What it demonstrates: ability to design, build, and ship an AI-enabled product prototype end-to-end — framework design, technical implementation, AI integration, and live deployment behind a portfolio site.

SELF-PUBLISHED RESEARCH · 2026

White Paper Series

Three independently authored papers · ForwardEd.consulting/white-papers

Original, research-grounded writing produced as personal thought leadership. Each paper builds on the last; together they form a single argument about K–12 structural integrity, intended to inform practitioner thinking and demonstrate research synthesis depth.

- **No. 1 — The Machine Beneath the Mission.** What AI reveals when trained on the full breadth of American education data.
- **No. 2 — Now That You Know, What Will You Do?** A research-grounded argument for whole-system instructional examination, sequenced for action.
- **No. 3 — The Mission on the Wall.** Why districts have missions they don't use, awards that don't mean what they should, and what that costs students.

AI Transparency: *All work is produced through structured collaboration with Claude (Anthropic). The author owns inquiry, framing, source verification, and final editorial judgment. Every claim is independently cross-referenced before publication.*

ORIGINAL IP · RESEARCH-CITED FRAMEWORK

MTSS Intervention Flowchart, 2026-27

Tiered support framework with parallel academic and behavior/SEL lanes

Designed an integrated, research-cited Multi-Tiered System of Supports framework that runs academic and behavior/SEL interventions in parallel — not as separate fiefdoms. Built around evidence-based thresholds (Fuchs & Fuchs; NCII/AIR) and the principle that data below threshold is a signal to review Tier 1 fidelity, not a referral trigger.

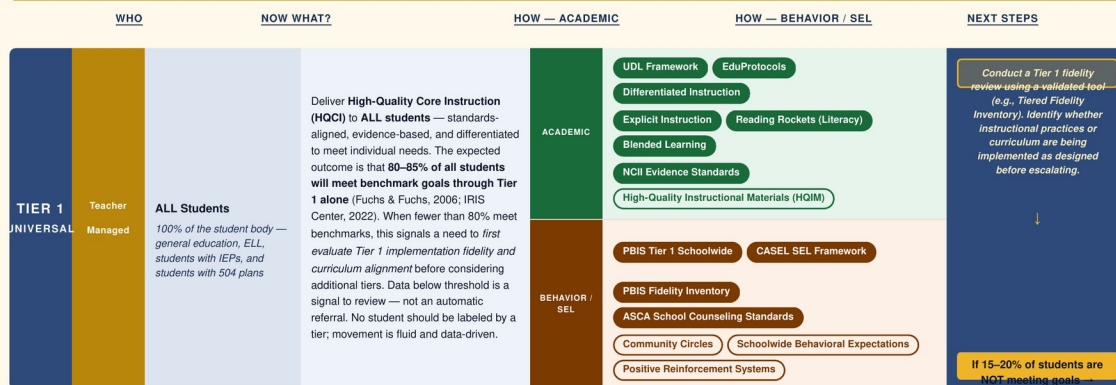
- **80–85% Tier 1 benchmark** — if fewer than 80% of students meet goals, evaluate instruction and curriculum, not students.
- **ICEL root-cause framework** (Instruction, Curriculum, Environment, Learner) drives diagnosis before prescription.
- **Cited research base** — 30+ peer-reviewed sources, including Fuchs & Fuchs (2006), IRIS Center (2022), Zhang et al. JELPS (2023), Thomas/Lembke/Gandhi (2023), NCII/AIR (2024).

MTSS INTERVENTION FLOWCHART

2026–2027 SCHOOL YEAR

This process wraps around the academic *and* social-emotional needs of the entire student body.
Academic and behavior tiers run in parallel and inform one another.

FIRST STEP: Universal Screening (3x/year) | Use validated screeners to identify at-risk students early and determine placement across tiered supports · Data drives decisions — not labels



MTSS Intervention Flowchart, 2026–27 · Tier 1 view (full framework available on request)



MTSS Intervention Flowchart, 2026–27 · Tiers 2 and 3 (Strategic and Intensive)

Track Record • K-12 Outcomes

Fifteen-plus years across California and South Carolina. Title I and private. Classroom, coaching, curriculum, founding-team administration. The work below is what produced the structural conviction behind ForwardEd — and demonstrates the ability to deliver measurable outcomes inside complex systems.

CASE STUDY 01 • PERFORMANCE TURNAROUND

Schoolwide Performance Turnaround

Inaugural Assistant Principal • Title I Middle School (~1,000 students)

CHALLENGE

A newly opened middle school faced inconsistent instructional practices, no aligned operating systems, and low baseline performance. Teams were working hard — but not in coordinated directions — and student outcomes reflected that.

ACTION

- Built and led a data-driven Professional Learning Community (PLC) operating system with consistent rhythms for planning, review, and adjustment.
- Implemented Plan-Do-Study-Act (PDSA) cycles across grade-level and content teams to drive continuous improvement.
- Delivered targeted professional development on MTSS, Universal Design for Learning (UDL), and high-impact instructional clarity.
- Established schoolwide instructional expectations and the monitoring infrastructure to maintain them.

RESULTS

- 10–15% increase in overall performance outcomes in a single year.
- 65%+ of students improved scores in both ELA and Mathematics.
- +6.6 point gain on California Science Test (CAST).
- Contributed directly to California Distinguished School recognition.

CORPORATE TRANSLATION

Enterprise-wide performance improvement initiative • cross-functional team alignment • KPI-driven execution under measurable goals.

CASE STUDY 02 • SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

MTSS System Design for Intervention

Tiered support architecture and decision framework

CHALLENGE

Existing intervention processes were symptom-focused rather than system-focused, leading

to over-referral, inconsistent decisions, and inefficient use of staff time and student time.

ACTION

- Designed and implemented a tiered support decision framework (MTSS) that routed students by objective criteria, not anecdote.
- Introduced an “80% rule” trigger model — if Tier 1 wasn’t reaching 80% of students, the issue belonged to instruction, not the student.
- Trained staff in root-cause analysis using the ICEL framework (Instruction, Curriculum, Environment, Learner) to diagnose before prescribing.
- Built the framework now published as the MTSS Intervention Flowchart, 2026–27 (see Section 01).

RESULTS

- Reduced unnecessary intervention referrals.
- Improved Tier 1 instructional effectiveness across grade levels.
- Increased staff clarity and consistency in support decisions.

CORPORATE TRANSLATION

Process optimization · decision-making framework design · operational efficiency · root-cause methodology applied at scale.

CASE STUDY 03 · CAPABILITY BUILDING

Instructional Coaching & Workforce Development

1:1 coaching, group training, and data-cycle iteration

CHALLENGE

Variability in instructional effectiveness across teams limited consistency in student outcomes and made performance gains hard to sustain.

ACTION

- Delivered 1:1 performance coaching paired with whole-team training cycles to build skill across the entire team, not just individuals.
- Modeled and implemented high-impact instructional strategies; coached staff through application.
- Used iterative data cycles to focus coaching on the practices most likely to move outcomes.
- Designed and delivered original professional learning sessions (sample slides below).

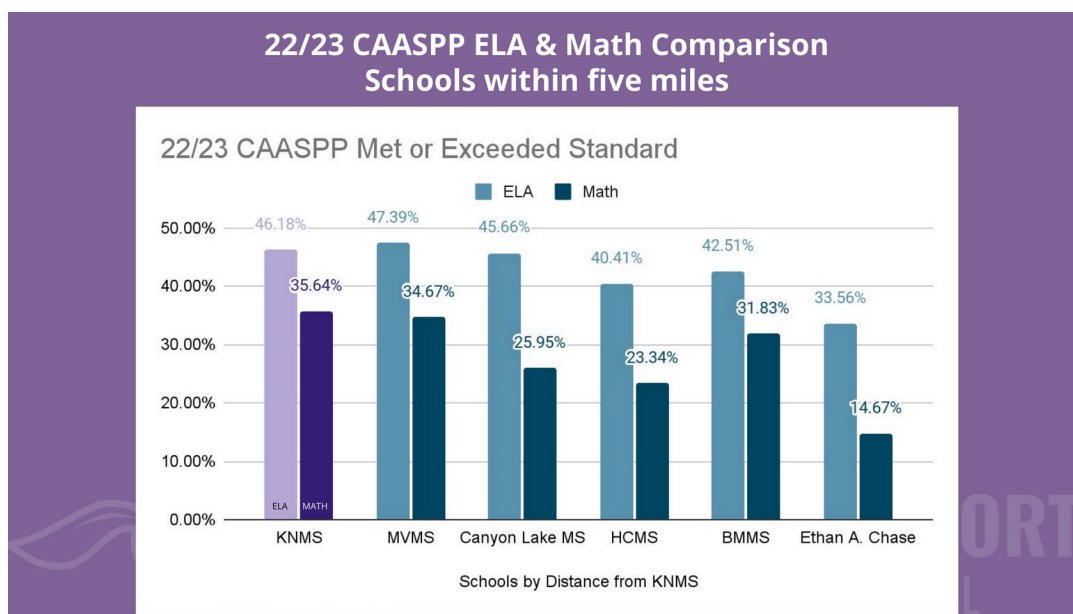
RESULTS

- Improved instructional consistency across teams.
- Strengthened internal capability and reduced reliance on external support.
- Direct contribution to measurable student performance gains.

CORPORATE TRANSLATION

Workforce development · performance coaching · upskilling and enablement · building

internal capability rather than buying it.



Professional Learning sample · comparative performance data analysis (Jan 2024)

CSTP 1 (Engaging and Supporting All Students in Learning) CREATE A POSTER

Informal Walkthroughs - CSTP 1 (Review)
In order for students to demonstrate engagement in the learning process, they should be able to answer the following questions in any given day. As the teacher in the classroom, how would *you* ensure that **all students** are able to answer these questions?

1. **What are you doing?** (the activity/task)
2. **What are you learning?** (the content/concept)
3. **Why are you learning it?** (the real-life connection/application)
4. **How do you know that you learned it?** (the feedback)

Professional Learning sample · CSTP-aligned instructional reflection protocol

CASE STUDY 04 · PROGRAM DEVELOPMENT

Curriculum Design & STEM Program Launch

MS Science Curriculum Design Team · DISCOVER STEM Academy

CHALLENGE

Students lacked engaging, future-focused learning pathways connecting academic work to real-world skills. Existing curriculum decisions were ad hoc and not coherently aligned across grade levels.

ACTION

- Led MS Science Curriculum Design Team through structured curriculum review and adoption process (NGSS toolkit rubrics, side-by-side publisher comparison, parent and educator input).
- Designed and launched the DISCOVER STEM Academy program — curriculum, structure, and operating model — from the ground up.
- Built stakeholder alignment across teachers, administrators, families, and community partners.
- Established a sustainable model designed to be maintained and expanded beyond initial launch.

RESULTS

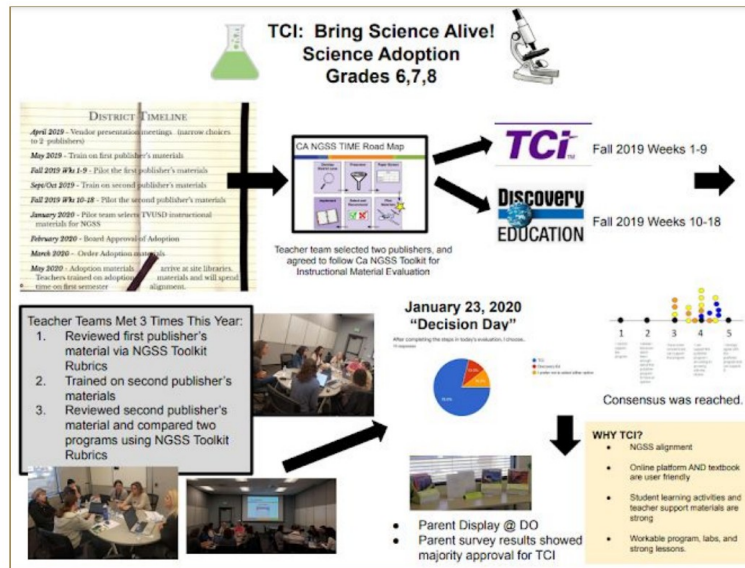
- Increased student engagement in STEM pathways.
- Reached cross-stakeholder consensus on curriculum direction.
- Established a sustainable, repeatable program model.

CORPORATE TRANSLATION

Product/program development · go-to-market planning · stakeholder alignment · launch and implementation · design for sustainability, not just launch.



MS Science Curriculum Design Team · launch deck (April 2022)



Curriculum review process · NGSS-aligned adoption decision documentation

CASE STUDY 05 · EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATION

Data & Systems Leadership

Site-wide performance analysis · Board-level communication

CHALLENGE

Site-wide performance data existed in volume, but leadership and board-level stakeholders needed it translated into clear narratives that drove decisions — not just reports.

ACTION

- Analyzed and synthesized site-wide performance data into executive-level summaries.
- Communicated insights and trends directly to leadership and board-level stakeholders.
- Drove decision-making by connecting data trends to strategic priorities and resource allocation.

RESULTS

- Improved strategic alignment between operational work and stated goals.
- Increased clarity in leadership decision-making.
- Supported measurable site-wide growth initiatives.

CORPORATE TRANSLATION

Executive communication · data storytelling · strategic advising · turning data into decisions for non-technical stakeholders.

[Artifact placeholder — board-level data summary or executive briefing slide. To be added once retrieved from former employer.]

How I Work

The operating commitments behind every framework, project, and team I've led.

Systems for Students First

When outcomes fall short, the instinct is to look at students first. I start somewhere different. I examine the structures and systems surrounding students, because that is where the answers most often live. Every decision begins and ends with one question: what does this do for student learning and wellbeing?

Design for All

Every educator enters this profession believing every child can learn. The challenge is building systems that make that belief a daily reality, not an aspiration. I help organizations design pathways where every learner has genuine access to the standards every facilitator commits to teaching — with the supports that make access real, not theoretical. Not about doing more. About designing better.

Burden Resolution

People are not burned out because they stopped caring. They are burned out because the systems around them were not designed to work coherently. I work to close that gap. When curriculum, instruction, and support are aligned around a shared purpose, the system begins doing the work it was supposed to do — and the burden begins to resolve. Not because the work gets easier, but because it finally makes sense.

Moral Clarity

Most practitioners already know what their people need. The harder question is what to do when the system, the politics, or the pressure make acting on that knowledge feel impossible. I believe knowing what people need — and having the professional courage to act on it, even when uncomfortable — is the defining responsibility of leadership. Not as a judgment. As a commitment we make together.

K-12 to Corporate Translation

How my K–12 experience maps to roles in EdTech, L&D, consulting, and operations — because most candidates fail in the translation, not the substance.

K-12 ROLE	CORPORATE EQUIVALENT
Classroom Teacher	Frontline performance operator
Instructional Coach	L&D / Enablement Lead
TOSA (Teacher on Special Assignment)	Program Manager / Implementation Specialist
Curriculum Designer	Senior Learning Designer / Content Strategist
Inaugural Assistant Principal	Operations Manager / Director of Operations

Core Competencies

Performance Improvement	Change Management	AI-Enabled Diagnostic Design
Program & Project Management	Process Optimization	Learning Design & Curriculum
Data Analysis & Insight Translation	Cross-Functional Leadership	Coaching & Capability Building
Stakeholder & Executive Communication	Strategic Planning	Systems Design & Implementation
Training & Professional Learning	Research Synthesis & Writing	Product Build & Launch

Ready for the next chapter.

I'm looking for full-time roles in L&D, EdTech, learning design, and program management — where measurable outcomes, structural thinking, and AI fluency matter, and where I can put 15+ years of work to use inside one organization.

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